

The Peace Accords

With all parties sitting down in Paris to discuss peace, hopes were high for a resolution of the conflict. However, many details had to be worked out, and some important issues were still outstanding when the final document was signed.

◀◀ BEFORE

Peace talks had been held in parallel with military action since 1968. From August 1969, additional peace talks were conducted in secret in Paris.

PRESSURED INTO PEACE

US bombing of strategic targets in North Vietnam in the wake of North Vietnam's 1972 **Easter Offensive** brought North Vietnam back to the negotiating table. Talks stalled in the fall of 1972 over South Vietnam's President Thieu's insistence that NVA troops should leave the South. **Bombing was resumed just before Christmas 1972.**

CONGRESSIONAL BLOCK

The American public was against the continuation of the Vietnam War, and so was Congress. In early January 1973, the Democratic majority in both houses of Congress voted to **deny military aid** when Nixon next requested it.

In a succession of messages over the Christmas holidays, Hanoi and Washington agreed to reopen the peace talks in Paris. On December 30, 1972, the US called a halt to the bombing of the North. By January 5, both sides were discussing ways in which a peace agreement would be enforced, including locations for checkpoints to monitor people and equipment entering or leaving South Vietnam. The agreement also included a provision that military equipment could be replaced on a one-for-one basis, which then raised the question of monitoring. It was decided that an International Commission for Control and Supervision (ICCS)—with contingents from Indonesia, Canada, Poland, and Hungary—would handle all such issues.

Details resolved

The Paris agreement provided for a “standstill” ceasefire, which left all military forces in the positions they occupied at the instant fighting stopped. This meant no North Vietnamese forces would leave South Vietnam, but all of the remaining American forces would withdraw and US prisoners of war would be handed back. Two joint military commissions would be created among the Vietnamese: a two-party one of South Vietnam and the National Liberation Front (NLF) to discuss enforcement of the ceasefire; and a four-party one (North Vietnam, South Vietnam, the US, and the NLF) concerned with overall issues. The two South Vietnamese parties were supposed to agree to work toward elections through a National Council of Reconciliation and Concord.

Kissinger flew to France and met with Le Duc Tho on January 8. The next day, the sides agreed on all outstanding issues in the agreement's main text, leaving only details to be settled. An additional lure for the South Vietnamese was the supply of extra equipment by the US in operations Enhance and Enhance Plus. To maximize South Vietnam's arsenal in advance of the Peace Accords, supplies included broken items that would be eligible for replacement under the one-for-one rule.

Kissinger reported the agreement as an achievement, but warned against too obvious a show of celebration, which might induce Hanoi to rescind its approval. By January 11, Kissinger and Nixon were deliberating on a schedule that would involve signing the agreement in Paris and Kissinger subsequently visiting Hanoi.